urbanization that will make India an urban-majority country within a generation. At one level, this will transform the economic, social and physical landscape of the country. At another level, Indian civilization has seen many such changes before and will take the shift in its stride.

When India became a republic in 1950, the share of urban population stood at 17 per cent, while China at 12 per cent was even more rural. The largest cities in India at that stage were Kolkata with a population of 2.6 million, followed by Mumbai at 1.5 million, Chennai at 0.8 million and Delhi at 0.7 million.[18] The Chinese cities of Shanghai and Peking (now Beijing) were much larger, at 3.8 million and 1.6 million respectively. Despite the damage done by war, Tokyo was the largest Asian city, with a population of 6.3 million. Tiny Singapore had less than one million, and not all of this population was urban.

Kolkata, or Calcutta as it was known then, was the country's pre-eminent city in the first two decades after independence. The political capital had shifted to New Delhi but Calcutta was the most important industrial, commercial and cultural hub of the country. It was the headquarters of many of the country's largest companies as well as of leading multinationals. Although it had lost part of its hinterland to East Pakistan, Calcutta's industrial cluster included British-era factories as well as new public sector establishments like Chittaranjan Locomotive Works. The nightlife in Park Street was said to be liveliest in Asia and the city's elite clubs buzzed with the rich and famous.

Unfortunately, it was too good to last. The rise of communism and militant trade unionism from the late sixties sapped the city's entrepreneurial spirit. Through the seventies and eighties, the city was repeatedly brought to a halt by strikes against 'capitalists', 'American imperialism', the central government and even against computers. One by one, the companies left and with them left the patronage for the arts and culture. Educational institutions also suffered from politicization. By the 1980s, the middle class, including me, began to leave in search of education and jobs. Mumbai clearly replaced Kolkata as the country's commercial capital; the latter has never made a serious bid to regain its position.